

NEW RUSSIA

WHAT IT MEANS TO THE WORLD AND TO INDIA

■ By Raj Chengappa in Moscow

As a 31-gun salute reverberated across the streets in Moscow and Vladimir Putin watched along with 2,000 dignitaries inside Kremlin's opulent gold-encrusted coronation hall, Dmitry Medvedev took oath as the third President of Russia on May 7. The swearing in of its youngest-ever president—Medvedev is just 42—saw the smoothest-ever transition in Russia's turbulent history. By handing over charge to his loyal aide of 17 years and still superbly fit at 55, Putin, who completed eight years of a successful Presidency, had become, as a diplomat watching the ceremony, put it, "The world's youngest older statesman."

With Putin taking over as prime minister and chairman of the ruling United Russia party which controls the Russian Parliament (the Duma) and the Federal Councils across the country, it was apparent that he would remain the defacto national leader. This unusual power sharing arrangement was necessitated by a constitutional limitation that barred Putin from contesting a third term even though his popularity ratings were at an all-time high.

So Putin endorsed Medvedev, the suave former professor of law-turned-politician and a fan of yesteryear rock band Deep Purple, as his successor. That saw his protégé win the March Presidential elections with a handsome majority. There is still speculation though over whether Russia could be ruled by two Czars. Analysts look at four possible answers to such a question: yes, no, don't know and nobody knows. Sergey Vykhukholev, deputy chief editor of Novosti, the Russian information agency, prefers the "nobody knows" answer as to how the new diumvirate will play out, as do many other experts.

Whatever the outcome, the most striking aspect of the new Russia is that the funeral-faced, boorish leadership that dominated its Soviet past has made way for youthful telly-savvy successors who ooze vitality. If Putin is a judo expert, who keeps track of his six-pack abs as he does of his country's GDP growth, Medvedev is all set to introduce a new fitness mantra for Russia: yoga. On the Sunday before he was sworn in, Medvedev took time off from his busy schedule for his favourite 'Artistic' yoga session that included alternating bouts of asanas and pranayamas and ending with the chanting of *Om*. Praising yoga's ability to help him beat the stress of his job, he recently told a Moscow glossy proudly, "I can even stand on my head."

Eight years ago in a similar swearing in ceremony, when Putin—then a political novice and a former KGB spy—took over from Boris Yeltsin, Russia was literally standing on its head for

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